or reduce Indian influence in India's traditional sphere of influence in South Asia and the Indian Ocean Region.

Binding strategies seek to constrain or enmesh targets in institutions, agreements, or other forms of interdependency that limit or reduce their ability to pursue autonomous foreign policies.[21] It means China would attempt to bind India closer to itself through institutions and economic interdependence.

Fourth, divide and balance strategies, which have been further developed by Crawford as *wedge strategies*, prevent enemy coalitions.[22] Crawford defines wedging as a state's attempt to "prevent, break up or weaken a threatening or blocking alliance."[23] It is naturally less costly to prevent an alliance from forming (pre-alignment) than to break up an already existing alliance (de-alignment). According to Crawford, states can use either selective accommodation or confrontation to achieve the objective. Although the perfect outcome would be re-alignment (convincing a state to align with you instead of with your main foe), neutrality, buck-passing, or hiding would be satisfactory results. I will explore if China is pursuing a wedge strategy towards India.

In order to avoid conceptual stretching of what balancing is, Kai He has identified four attributes that have to be fulfilled for a policy to qualify as a balancing strategy. First, it has to be a policy pursued by the state. Second, it has to be a strategy for obtaining security from external threats. Third, it must be aimed at changing a state's relative power vis-à-vis a rival or adversary to its own favour. And, fourth, the strategy must have a particular target.[24]

I will now examine how balance of power in the international system, India's threat to stability on China's western frontier, China's geostrategy, and its shifting priorities on wealth and power to various degrees have informed China's pursuit of different balancing strategies (wedge, proxy balancing, public-goods substitution, and binding) towards India.